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1 & 2 Chronicles

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1 & 2 Chronicles

Overview and Summary. The two books were originally one book in the Jewish Scriptures but it is one consistent narrative. It contains much of the same content as the books of Samuel and Kings which precede it in our modern Bibles. In the Jewish Scripture, it is the last book as it summarizes all the other books. It begins with Adam in First Chronicles and ends with the return of the Jews after the Babylonian exile in Second Chronicles. It was written looking to the past with a retelling of the story of David and Solomon and other kings as a means of looking to the future and hope for a coming Messiah and the hope for a new temple. The author is not known. Because it repeats so much material, we will summarize the chapters here.

A. The first nine chapters of First Chronicles provide a lengthy record of genealogies from Adam to David. The storyline of the Old Testament is given by naming key figures in this narrative. The book chronicles two lines: that of King David, which will lead to the coming Messiah and that of the High Priest, who will serve in the coming temple.

B. Then come twenty chapters all about David. The material is familiar from the book of Samuel. However, the negative aspects of David's life where he is portrayed as weak and immoral are not included such as his being pursued by King Saul, as well as his adultery with Bathsheba, and the murder of her husband. What is left presents David in a positive light including new material, where David makes preparations for the building of the temple. This is to make David an image of the coming future Messiah. Jeremiah prophesied: "Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will raise up for David a righteous Branch, and he shall reign as king and deal wisely, and shall execute justice and righteousness in the land. In his days Judah will be saved, and Israel will dwell securely. And this is the name by which he will be called: 'The LORD is our righteousness'" (Jeremiah 23:5-6). First Chronicles ends with David dying: "full of days, riches and honor" and Solomon reigning in his place (Vs. 29:28).

C. After the death of David, Second Chronicles focuses on the kings that lived in Jerusalem. The kings of the Northern Kingdom of Israel are excluded. This is to present the kings within the line of David that will lead to the Messiah. The author

highlights those kings of Judah that were obedient to God, resulting in God's blessing. The unfaithful actions of other kings are presented that led Judah into idolatry, and sin leading up to the Jew's exile.

D. Second Chronicles ends with the destruction of Jerusalem by the Babylonians (Vs. 36:17-21). But the final words of the book are a quote from King Cyrus of the Persians: " Now in the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of the LORD by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled, the LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia, so that he made a proclamation throughout all his kingdom and also put it in writing: "Thus says Cyrus king of Persia, 'The LORD, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth, and he has charged me to build him a house at Jerusalem, which is in Judah. Whoever is among you of all his people, may the LORD his God be with him. Let him go up'" (Vs. 36:22-23).

E. Discussion questions, application and passing it on.

1. First and Second Chronicles looks back to see God's promises and narratives in order to give hope to the Jews of the coming Messiah. Can you look back on your life to see God's interaction with you? Does this give you hope for the fulfillment of God's promises for the future?
2. Develop a short narrative of your personal history culminating in your rebirth and how you see hope in the future return of Jesus. Purpose to share this narrative with someone in the near future.

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)